role in this area. China also started to supply arms to Mizo insurgents that year. Chinese military leader Lin Biao's reiteration of Chinese sympathy and support for revolutionaries in India at the ninth party congress in April only heightened Indian concerns. The formation that month of the extremist Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist), which looked to Beijing for guidance, did not help, even though, at least initially, they did not receive the amount of assistance they sought.[35]

Uncertainties in India's relations with its eastern and northeastern neighbors only increased worries about its vulnerability vis-à-vis China. In 1969, Sikkim's leader broached the subject of revising the 1950 treaty, which had established Sikkim as a protectorate of India.[36] In addition, the Nepalese prime minister canceled an arms assistance agreement with India and demanded that India reduce its presence in Nepal. He denied that Beijing was urging these steps, but Chinese reports praised Kathmandu's stance. Gandhi believed that the Nepalese leadership, in turn, was "encouraging" Beijing.[37] Finally, Indian officials remained concerned about increasing Chinese influence and presence in northern Burma.[38]

Indian concerns about China also persisted because of hostile rhetoric from Beijing. China protested intrusion by all things Indian—from aircraft to linoleum. Beijing also continued to accuse Delhi of colluding with Washington to exploit China's vulnerability in Tibet. Furthermore, Haksar noted the Chinese efforts to use "India's dependence on Western aid" to undermine it in other parts of the developing world.[39]

With its efforts to reach out to China going nowhere, the Gandhi government engaged with other countries to contain and mitigate the China threat. It looked east, where there were "serious apprehensions" about China, with Gandhi visiting Indonesia and Japan, and Indian deputy prime minister Morarji Desai and the chief of naval staff also traveling to the region. Concerned about Southeast Asia's vulnerability to China, a potential vacuum if the US withdrew, and its own relative neglect of the area, India made efforts—not always successful—to reach out to these countries.[40] Closer to home, to assuage Nepalese concerns, India downgraded its military presence in Nepal. Nonetheless, to maintain its influence—and not create a vacuum that China might fill—India rejected Nepalese calls for substantial changes in the broader Indo-Nepalese security framework.[41] To